

> **"India is a major global player, not a British colony, and everyone must accept this reality. Furthermore, PM Modi is not someone who succumbs to pressure easily"**

> **"The Indian people can certainly take pride in their leader. PM Modi's stance is unwavering and straightforward, without being confrontational"**

> **"PM Modi sets very challenging tasks for the country, for the administration and for himself. His famous pitch, Make in India, has a practical dimension, including for our bilateral relations"**

Q. How do you assess the strength of the India-Russia friendship at this point and what would you say *about* Prime Minister Narendra Modi and *to* Prime Minister Narendra Modi, whom you call your *dost*?

A. You know, the world is evolving rapidly—and this pace keeps getting faster, which is plainly visible to all. The global configuration is changing, with new centres of power emerging, and the global power landscape is changing too. Therefore, it's crucial to ensure stability among major nations, since this forms the groundwork for gradual progress in both bilateral and international relations. In this context, our collaborative endeavours with Prime Minister Modi carry significant weight because they transcend our mutual ties. Given its direct relevance to both nations, ensuring stability in key areas of engagement is crucial, as it helps secure the fulfilment of our objectives. Prime Minister Modi sets very challenging tasks for the country—and for himself in the first place, then for the administration and, eventually, for the nation. Take, for example, his famous pitch, 'Make in India'. It has a practical dimension, including for our bilateral relations. When we meet, he always says, "Let's do this, let's do that, let's look at this area and that." I can list them all. Therefore, we have a lot of practical areas of cooperation.

Q. When you met Prime Minister Modi at the SCO [Shanghai Cooperation Organisation] recently, there was a video of you and him going in the same car. Was this preplanned and what did you discuss?

A. We had just gone over the current topics. This wasn't prearranged; we simply stepped out, and my car was waiting. I asked, "Would you like to come along?" That's all there is to it—a gesture of human solidarity, camaraderie and friendship. No hidden scheme was involved. We climbed into the car like old friends and talked en route. We always have things to discuss.

Q. You just said that both leaders are going to cement the guarantees that you gave each other. What kind of announcements can we expect?

A. We have laid out an ambitious plan for our collaboration in key domains. The most critical areas are indeed forward-looking. I'm referring specifically to high technology. Our partnership with India encompasses such fields as space exploration, energy (notably nuclear power, exemplified by the prominent Kudankulam Nuclear Power Plant project), shipbuilding and aviation. There are many interesting areas for cooperation that are looking to the future. Take, for example, artificial intelligence, which represents a crucial technology shaping the future, rapidly transforming the